

Article | 19 August 2026

RATES SPARK

Rates Spark: The Treasury's plan for the back end

It's clear that the US Treasury is ready to place a limit to the upside for longer-dated yields. The impact of the increased buybacks is not so much on the doubling of them in long dates, but more so on the implied reality that they could be doubled again, and again if needed. But given what we have now, and until then, upward pressure on long yields will remain



With the US Treasury doubling the buybacks of long-dated bonds, there is the possibility they could do it again and again

As noted [here](#), the Treasury's decision to increase buybacks in longer durations smacks of discomfort with the sell-off seen in longer tenor Treasury securities of late. It's been impactful, with the 10-30-year yields down 5-10bp to begin with. The official genesis of the buyback programme, back in May 2024, was to bolster liquidity, and indeed, that was the rationale employed to explain away the announced doubling of buyback sizes in the 10yr to 30yr maturities. If we annualise the quarterly rhythm, that nets an additional US\$18bn of buybacks through these tenors. That stretches the buyback programme from US\$38bn to US\$56bn (of which US\$36bn in the 10-30 yrs). On top of that, there is US\$25bn in the 1-2 year area for cash management purposes. While the entire buyback programme is actually less in size than one regular 2yr auction event, it's still chunky.

We've also made the point that these buybacks need to be subsequently re-financed. And they do. However, the important nuance here is that for any given steady-state coupon issuance rhythm (which we've had and are likely to continue to have), any additional buybacks must, by definition, be financed through extra bills issuance (as bills are the variable that the Treasury must deploy with on a fixed bond issuance programme). This morphs the impact of the additional buybacks into a structural impact on long-dated bonds outstanding, as they effectually get replaced by rolling bills issuance. It's a zero-sum game from the Treasuries perspective, but from the markets' perspective, it adds to bills issuance, and has a bigger effect through lower long-duration net issuance.

We'd maintain the view that this move is unlikely on its own to change the trajectory for long-end yields. It does mute it though. And moreover, it reminds the market that the Treasury could double the long tenor buyback sizes again, and again if needed. That's the real kicker from this move: the anticipation for more should long-dated yields decide to morph higher again in an overly sinister fashion in the days and weeks and months ahead. Given that, we'd continue to identify upward pressure on long-end yields as a dominant factor that the market will need to deal with. But muted it absolutely is.

Note that this is not quantitative easing. It is long-end buying by the Treasury, effectively financed through buying more bills. As a stand-alone factor, it places a flattening impulse on the curve, thus muting the net steepening that we continue to anticipate. We're still of the opinion that the 10yr yield has a risk factor move in it to the 4.75% to 5% zone. And for now, it's unlikely to get much below 4.5%, but one thing has become more clear from this is any move above 5% (or even the material threat thereof), would likely be actively resisted/prevented by the US Treasury Department.

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Article | 25 August 2026

COMMODITIES DAILY

The Commodities Feed: Oil shrugs off Bessent's 'D-day' plan for Iran

Oil prices drifted lower yesterday despite renewed US plans to tighten economic pressure on Iran. Meanwhile, anxiety is building in Europe's gas market as storage levels look increasingly fragile heading into the heating season



Energy - EU gas prices continue to move higher

Oil prices are steady this morning, holding onto yesterday's losses after ICE Brent closed 2.35% lower. The market seems largely unfazed by Washington's push for tighter economic pressure on Iran, with traders treating the US effort to nudge partners away from Iranian trade as marginal rather than market-moving. The US announced more than 70 Iran-related sanctions and is threatening secondary sanctions on those that do not cut trading ties with Iran. However, China is the largest buyer of Iranian energy. It remains unclear whether the US would risk a fragile trade truce with Beijing over secondary sanctions. The market is still awaiting further details on a possible timeline for trading partners to wind down ties with Iran.

Supply concerns continue to grow in the European natural gas market, particularly with storage levels, as the region moves closer towards the heating season. TTF front-month futures settled more than 3.7% higher yesterday, with prices breaking above EUR68/MWh and

to their highest level since March. EU gas storage is a little under 63% full, below the 5-year average of 80% and also lower than the almost 76% seen at the same stage last year. At the current rate, it will be difficult for the EU to hit even the lower storage target of 75% ahead of the heating season. This raises the prospects of forced buying, increasing upside risk for gas prices.

Metals – Copper supported by fresh LME inventory drawdowns

Copper edged higher after fresh withdrawals from LME warehouses renewed concerns over tight exchange inventories. LME cancelled warrants increased by 51.4kt, the largest daily rise since May. Most cancellations were concentrated in US and Asian locations. The move follows last week's squeeze in the nearby market, which pushed prompt premiums to record levels.

Recent deliveries into LME warehouses helped ease some of the tightness. However, the latest withdrawal suggests that any recovery in inventories may prove temporary. Inventory movements remain a key focus, with exchange stocks still relatively low.

Copper remains supported by strong metal flows into the US. Elevated US premiums are encouraging shipments into the country, tightening availability elsewhere.

Meanwhile, record-high prices are raising demand concerns, particularly in China. Physical market conditions remain healthy, but buyers are becoming more cautious as prices continue to climb.

Copper has also found support from a weaker US dollar and remains up almost 15% year-to-date.

For now, tight inventories and continued US-bound flows remain the dominant drivers, leaving the market vulnerable to further bouts of tightness and volatility.

Agriculture – Corn rises on lower yield expectations

CBOT corn prices extended their rally yesterday, as expectations for a smaller US harvest and ongoing Black Sea tensions raise supply concerns. The recent Pro Farmer crop tour pegged the US corn crop at 15.3bn bushels with an average yield of 173.2bu/acre, well below the USDA's production estimate of 16.01bn bushels and yield estimate of 180.7bu/acre.

EU corn yields are set to weaken further, with the European Commission's latest MARS crop report estimating output at 6.61t/ha, down from a previous projection of 6.93t/ha, and below the five-year average of 7.1t/ha. Persistent hot and dry weather across Western and Central Europe significantly reduced summer crop yields. Yield estimates for wheat rose from 5.66t/ha to 5.68t/ha, in line with the five-year average.

Meanwhile, the Indian Sugar Mills Association (ISMA) lowered its 2025/26 gross sugar

production forecast to 30.9mt from an initial estimate of 34.5mt (including volumes diverted to ethanol production). It cited adverse weather, lower cane yields, and weaker sugar recovery rates. Annual domestic demand is estimated at 28 to 28.5mt. To bolster domestic availability and curb prices, the government has introduced a duty-free import window, tightened stock-holding limits, continued special crushing operations, and facilitated an early start to the new harvest.

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Article | 24 August 2026

RATES SPARK

Rates Spark: It's about bigger buybacks, not how its financed

Deployment of the Treasury General Account as a financing mechanism for buybacks is an option. But really, it's no different to structural financing through bills, especially as the buffer is re-built. It's all about timing. That apart, eurozone growth may not grab headlines, but is beating consensus, adding to the upward pressure on euro rates



The best way to view effect of the buyback is by a narrowing of the swap spreads, which has already happened

The Treasury buyback story gets ballooned by talk of TGA deployment

We opined on talk that the US Treasury could deploy its deposit balances to finance buybacks of Treasuries [here](#). We make the basic point that deployment of financing from the Treasury General Account (TGA) does not have a material effect on the potential for buybacks. They could just as easily be financed through bills issuance. The key messaging here is not on how the buybacks are financed, but on the threat that the buybacks could be increased again, and again, in the future should the US Treasury deem it a suitable policy. It kicks off from 9 September, and is liable to be more than double to begin with in any case, as already intimated by the Treasury Secretary.

Has the policy been effective? The absolute level of Treasury yields is of course relevant, but is only part of the story. The best way to view the effect of the buyback policy is through swap spreads. As Treasury yields fall relative to SOFR rates, the swap spread narrows, and that is what has happened. The 30yr swap spread tightened by 4bp when the doubling of long-end buybacks was announced. And narrowed by a further 3bp through Monday. In our opinion, this outcome is not because of talk of financing buybacks through the TGA. It's because such talk gives the clear impression that the buyback programme could be further expanded in the months ahead.

Improving eurozone growth adds to upward rates pressure

US headlines continue to grab markets' attention, but the underlying growth story in the eurozone should not be ignored, albeit the signals are more subtle. The eurozone's economic data have consistently beat consensus expectations over the past few months. In fact, the last time economic surprises were this much tilted into positive territory was in 2023. Of course, one could argue that expectations are also more subdued given the ongoing geopolitical turmoil and the consequential higher energy costs. But still, even in absolute terms, data such as PMIs are mostly well in positive growth territory.

An improving growth picture combined with still very positive market sentiment means more upside risk for euro rates. Even the release of Germany's Ifo survey outcomes on Tuesday could contribute to the drift higher. A further improvement in the German economic outlook would give confidence to the European Central Bank regarding a potential rate hike in September. So unless oil and gas prices make a significant turn lower, euro rates are unlikely to ease for now.

Tuesday's events and market view

In terms of data, EUR rates will mainly focus on Germany's Ifo business sentiment indicator. Last week's flash PMI had seen the services sector disappoint, but it saw a surprisingly strong reading for manufacturing.

In the US, we will be getting the Conference Board's consumer confidence index for August, along with the July new home sales and building permit numbers. The Fed's Barkin will be speaking on two occasions.

In the government bond primary markets, Germany will auction €5bn in 2y bonds while the UK sells £4bn in 7y gilts. The US auctions US\$69bn of new 2y notes.

The broader Sovereign, Supranational and Agency (SSA) market also remains active. We have seen mandates from German Land Berlin (10Y) and French Ile de France Mobilites (10y EuGB) at the start of the week. From the Supras, the World Bank

mandated a new EUR bond (10y sustainable) while the ESM is in the market for a new 5y US\$ bond.

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HUNGARY

National Bank of Hungary preview: More clues for more cuts

Hungary's 'mini rate cut cycle' is coming to an end, but further easing remains likely, particularly because of the recent improvement in inflation. The central bank will probably wait for the September forecast update before committing. We see a below-5% base rate by year-end



Mihaly Varga, Governor of the National Bank of Hungary

Our call

In line with the central bank's commitment to a summer 'mini rate-cut cycle', another rate cut in August will come as little surprise. Since the July meeting, the macro and market backdrop has done nothing but strengthen the case for an expansion of the rate cut cycle. However, one step at a time: we anticipate a 25bp reduction in the base rate, taking it down to 5.50% on 25 August.

Looking ahead, Governor Varga said that the next key moment for monetary policy would be the September Inflation report and its updated staff projections. We do not doubt that, when the time comes, the central bank will express even greater optimism about the inflation trajectory. July's headline inflation print of 1.2% YoY was even lower than the central bank's latest forecasted uncertainty band for the data. This suggests that the inflation path will need to be revised downwards further over the monetary policy horizon, with energy prices and the

EUR/HUF exchange rate remaining more or less unchanged (even though volatility has remained elevated).

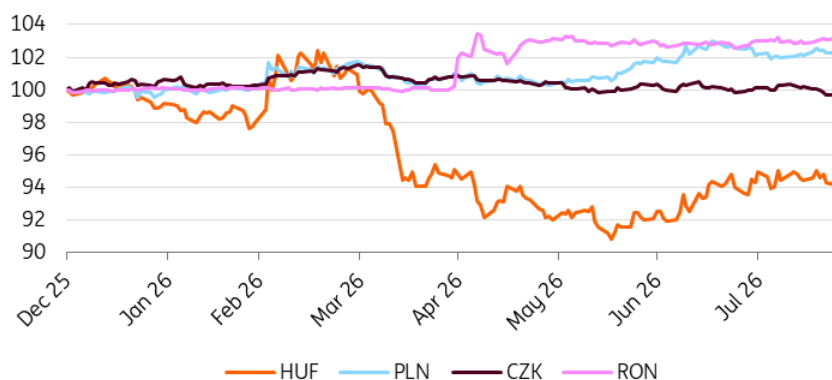
We forecast a terminal rate of 4.75% for this year.

Against this backdrop and assuming there are no black swan events in the form of another geopolitical or energy crisis, we forecast a 'mid-sized' rate cut cycle involving three further cuts following the move in August. At a local level, we believe that Hungary could receive further structural market support if the right steps are taken to secure as much RRF funding as possible, and if this year's budgetary revision is both honest and credible. Therefore, we forecast a terminal rate of 4.75% for this year, which would still provide a sufficient risk premium and positive real interest rate to preserve market stability.

Our market views

The Hungarian forint repeatedly tested the 366 EUR/HUF level in August, its weakest level since the April elections. A mix of global geopolitical uncertainty, local energy supply concerns and crowded long positioning pushed EUR/HUF higher. Despite higher rate volatility, markets still keep a dovish bias on Hungary relative to the rest of the region, leaving the overall backdrop unfavourable for the forint.

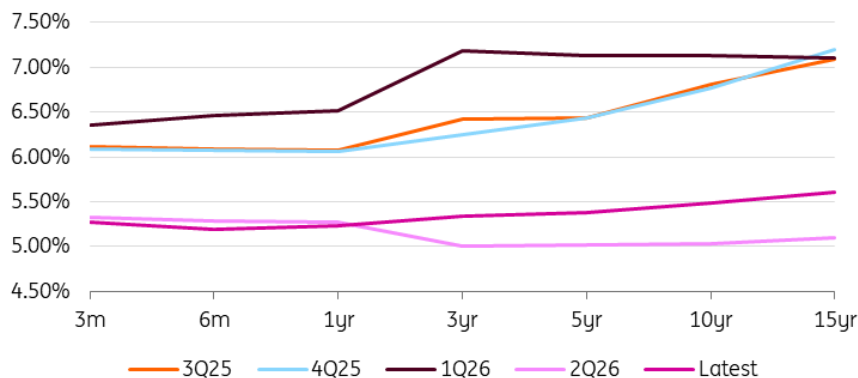
CEE FX performance vs EUR (end-2025 = 100%)



Source: NBH, ING

That said, most of these headwinds should prove temporary, and we expect market sentiment to turn more supportive again. In our view, EUR/HUF remains range-bound, with less scope for a rally than in fixed income. Still, levels above 364 look cheap if global sentiment improves.

Hungarian yield curve



Source: GDMA, ING

Rates now price in around 70bp of easing, including the August meeting, keeping Hungary an outlier within EMEA. Despite repeated downside inflation surprises, markets have stayed cautious amid geopolitical risks and reduced rate cut bets in July and August. We see scope for more easing to be priced in and for the curve to steepen, although – as with FX – this depends on some improvement in global sentiment.

Some background

[Inflation edged lower again in July](#) despite the global energy price shock sparked by geopolitical tensions. The forint's strength continues to exert a powerful stabilising influence on prices, prompting us to revise our inflation outlook lower once more. We now forecast average inflation of just 1.7% in 2026, reinforcing our conviction that substantial monetary easing remains on the cards for the rest of the year. Meanwhile, [second-quarter GDP](#) data offered little evidence of an overheating economy or any imminent build-up of demand-driven inflation pressures.

Recent forint volatility is a reminder that the central bank cannot afford to be complacent. But even after EUR/HUF neared 367, it has recovered on the back of global sentiment. It is now hovering around the levels seen at the previous rate-setting meeting, around 362. The same can be said about Hungarian government bond yields, which have been fluctuating in a tight range over the last month.

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RATES SPARK

Rates Spark: US long-end under increasing scrutiny

US and EUR long-end yields remain under pressure from fiscal concerns, resilient growth, energy risks and renewed supply, keeping bearish steepening risks intact even as benign US inflation supports the front end



Long-end yields remain under pressure amid fiscal concerns

US: A bearish steepening theme is more likely to persist

The US long end will remain under scrutiny. The US Treasury's attempt to dampen the rise under the guise of scaled-up liquidity operations has only drawn more attention to the underlying issue, the growing debt load and the limited ability or willingness to rein in the US deficit. While it has been signalled that some announcements to cut back on wasteful spending will be made in coming days, without a big rethink coming from Congress, we are only looking at trimming the edges.

There are other factors aggravating the situation in bond markets, such as the tech-related issuance (markets will be paying attention to this week's earnings) and, on the monetary policy side, the ongoing concern with inflation. On the latter, some of the heat has come off though. The market will be looking to the Federal Reserve's favoured inflation measure, the core PCE, this Wednesday. But the CPI release has already been benign alongside other indicators, e.g. producer prices.

That means Fed Chair Kevin Warsh might be under less pressure to provide the clarity the market is seeking when he delivers his speech at this year's Jackson Hole conference on Friday. The market is down to discounting 10bp of tightening for September, which translates into the implied probability of a hike of 40%. At the start of this month, we were above 70%.

Overall, the front end might stay better supported, but the issues plaguing the long end are not going away. We think this leaves a curve twisting steeper or even outright bearish steepening theme intact as our base case. We had flagged last week that 10y US Treasury yields could well test beyond the 4.75% towards 5%.

EUR: The long-end has been an issue, but there is no letup in short-end pressure

Elevated deficits and high debt loads are not only a US issue, but something European bond markets have grappled with for some time already. France and Italy are the main concern currently, but even Germany is facing scrutiny with record-high issuance planned also in the years ahead. 10y Bund yields have risen to above 3.25% over the past week, the highest since 2011, albeit in a less volatile fashion.

The underlying energy situation, with increasing concerns surrounding gas prices, remains a more meaningful driver in the near term that keeps the market's pricing of the European Central Bank aggressive even beyond the September meeting. And we are likely to see an energy-related rise in the flash CPIs coming from the individual countries this week, keeping that pressure alive. On the growth side, the latest round of flash PMIs pointed to an economy staying surprisingly resilient, offering the rates market little relief. We will be looking to Germany's Ifo release on Tuesday, but even here, the consensus is looking for a small improvement.

A more technical driver that has perhaps played more into the timing of the rise in bond yields is the resumption of issuance activities after the summer break. We have seen the first government bond syndicated issuances, including a German 30y tap. But the broader SSA market has also gained steam with German issuers testing the waters.

Monday's events and market view

It will be a slow start to the week in terms of scheduled calendar events. We will be mainly looking for headlines around the US deficit, with officials having touted coming announcements to curb spending. On the geopolitical front, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent will provide more detail on US plans to increase the economic pressure on Iran in a press conference today.

In the primary government bond markets, Belgium will auction 5y, 10y and 20y bonds for a total of €2.6-3bn.

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Article | 24 August 2026

FX

FX Daily: Dollar soft, US policy in spotlight

The dollar opens the week on a soft footing as the market awaits fresh policy updates from the White House. These include economic D-Day for Iran and perhaps some kind of US fiscal consolidation plan promised after stress in the Treasury market last week. Most paths seem to lead to a weaker dollar, but Kevin Warsh's speech on Friday could prove supportive.



There may still be room for further USD long-squeezing, and we remain reluctant to call the bottom in this dollar selloff just yet

↓ USD: US economic policy in focus

It has been a quiet start to the week in Asia, but the dollar remains near its recent lows. We made the point last week that we tend to favour a more [pro-risk, benign dollar decline](#) than some, but there are many in favour of sharper dollar losses on a return of the 'debasement' trade. That could be tested later today, with US Treasury Secretary, Scott Bessent, announcing a new set of sanctions on Iran. With a new chapter in the US-Canada trade war opening up over the weekend, the question will be to what degree the new sanctions on Iran threaten US trade ties with China again, where China remains the largest buyer of Iran's energy imports. Given the febrile mood in the market and positioning, a big re-escalation in the tariff war is

probably a dollar negative.

The other big US policy announcement in focus is the prospect of fiscal consolidation dangled by Bessent last week. Given Washington's firmly pro-growth mind-set, few expect any substantial spending cuts or tax rises, with the burden probably placed on efficiency gains. Clearly, the US Treasury market is not out of the woods yet and this week the focus will also be on Thursday's \$44bn auction of seven-year Treasuries.

Also, important this week are Wednesday's release of US core PCE inflation for July and Friday afternoon's keynote speech from Kevin Warsh at the Jackson Hole symposium. While he is unlikely to shed much/any light on what the Fed will do with monetary policy next month, he will have to double-down on the Fed's inflation-fighting credentials - this after his July press conference triggered a sell-off at the long-end of the Treasury market. The speech could be a hawkish event risk for the dollar.

DXY dollar index can probably see further consolidation in a 98.50-99.00 range today, with greater risk seen on the downside.

Chris Turner

↑ **EUR: Positioning favours the euro**

Latest positioning data from the futures market in Chicago points to asset managers and leveraged funds buying euro contracts. The amounts are not particularly large and the data does predate last Wednesday's jump in EUR/USD, but this does serve as a reminder that speculators look quite underweight the euro. This was the same conclusion we drew when looking at the [EUR/USD hedging data](#).

On the calendar this week is the release of the August German IFO tomorrow. Like the [Eurozone PMIs](#), this is expected to continue its recovery after the sharp drop witnessed in March and April.

We do not really see the need for EUR/USD to come back sharply under support at 1.1660/70 today, but last week's break-out area would be the risk if risk assets started to suffer. At present, we are happy with our [current forecasts](#) for EUR/USD at 1.17 end September and 1.18 for end year - but will be reviewing those this week.

Chris Turner

↓ **CAD: Trade war escalates**

Trade negotiations between the US and Canada have temporarily broken down, with both sides re-imposing tariffs on the other. As a smaller, more open economy, Canada has more to lose from this, but Prime Minister Mark Carney seems to have opened the door to more fiscal

stimulus to support affected business.

After a very strong run recently, the Canadian dollar has come under some pressure. The correction in USD/CAD could extend to the 1.380/3910 area, but we suspect USD sellers will return there.

Chris Turner

➔ TRY: CBT restarts one week repo operations

In some welcome news out of Turkey, the Central Bank of Turkey announced over the weekend that it would be restarting the one-week repo operations. This means that funding operations switch to the 37% policy rate and away from the 40% overnight lending rate. Recall that the one-week repo operations were suspended in early March at the outbreak of US-Iran hostilities and the CBT effectively delivered a 300bp rate hike.

A return to more traditional funding policy looks to be a sign of confidence from local policymakers. TRY short-dated implied yields have dropped on the news and those positioned in the carry trade, expecting the lira to outperform the forwards, will likely stay invested.

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Article | 21 August 2026

COMMODITIES, FOOD & AGRI

Is gold back?

Gold has rebounded sharply from its July lows, supported by renewed investment demand and growing unease over the US fiscal outlook. But persistent inflation and the possibility of further Fed tightening mean the recovery is unlikely to be straightforward



Growing concerns over the US fiscal situation and investment demand are giving momentum to gold prices

Fiscal risks give gold fresh momentum

Gold has climbed from around \$4,000/oz in mid-July to around \$4,600/oz, returning to levels last seen in May.

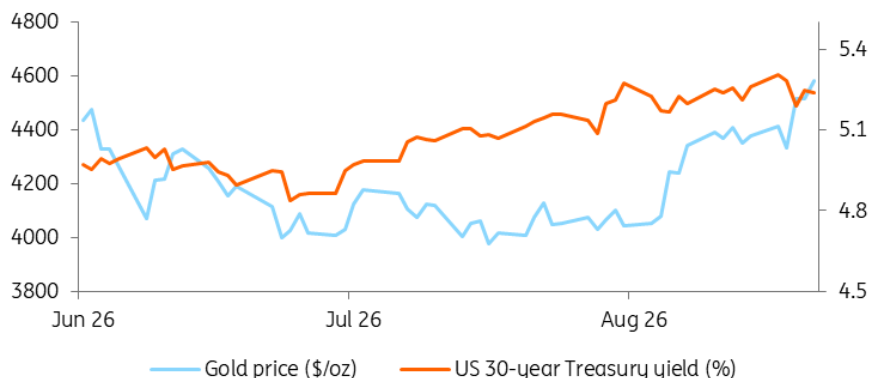
The latest move followed the US Treasury's decision to increase its purchases of longer-dated government debt. The maximum size of buyback operations in the 10-to-30-year segment will rise from \$2bn to at least \$4bn, with Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent signalling that the programme could be expanded further.

The bond-market impact proved short-lived, with long-term yields subsequently recovering much of their decline. Gold, however, continued to strengthen.

In our view, gold's resilience suggests that the rally is not simply a response to lower yields. The prospect of larger Treasury buybacks has refocused attention on government borrowing and fiscal credibility. It has also revived concerns about currency debasement, reinforcing

gold's appeal as a store of value.

Gold rebounds despite elevated long-term yields



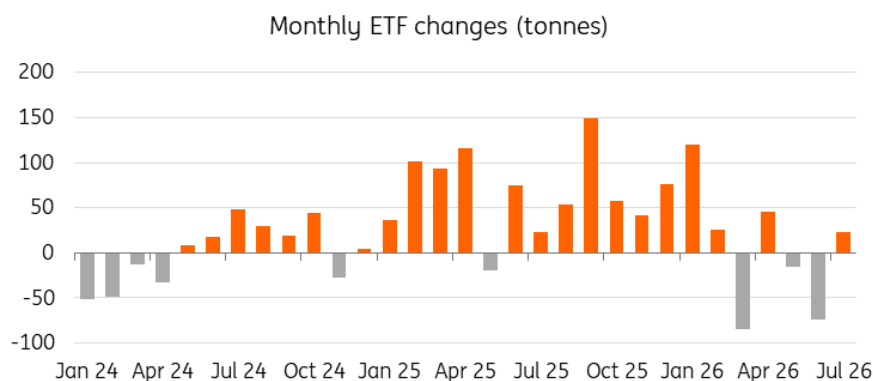
Source: Refinitiv, ING Research

A weaker dollar and lower short-term yields have helped gold rebound after prices found support around \$4,000/oz in mid-July. Softer US data have also revived expectations that the Fed could begin easing policy in 2027.

Investment demand is recovering

The improvement in ETF demand is another positive signal. Global gold-backed ETFs attracted \$3bn in July, lifting their holdings by 23 tonnes, according to the World Gold Council.

Gold ETF inflows return



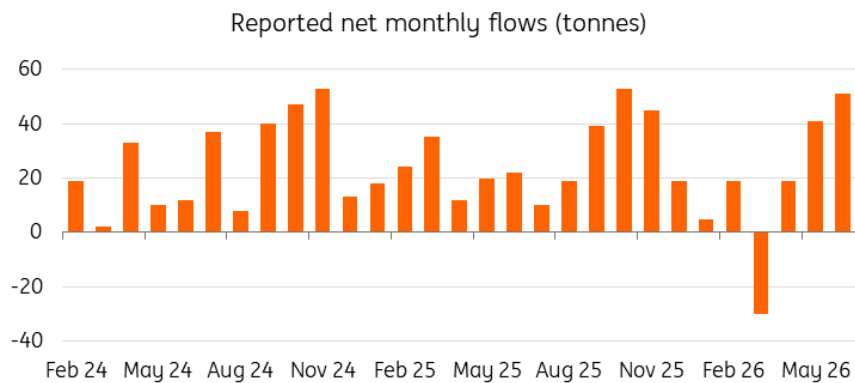
Source: WGC, ING Research

The recovery has continued into August. Funds tracked by Bloomberg added around 18 tonnes on Thursday alone, their strongest daily accumulation in almost a year.

Central banks also remain a significant source of demand. Reported net purchases reached 51

tonnes in June, taking the first-half total to 102 tonnes, with Poland and China leading the buying. We expect official-sector buying to continue supporting the market, but further gains will increasingly depend on whether Western investors maintain their renewed interest in gold.

Central bank purchases rebound



Source: WGC, ING Research

Inflation remains the main headwind

The rally still faces headwinds. Rising energy prices are adding to US price pressures and could keep monetary policy restrictive for longer.

[Minutes from the Fed's July meeting](#) showed that some policymakers favoured an immediate rate increase, while others were prepared to support further tightening if inflation remained elevated.

The Fed's annual Jackson Hole symposium from 27 to 29 August will be closely watched. Any indication that policymakers are becoming more willing to raise rates would risk lifting yields and the dollar. A greater focus on growth or financial stability would be more supportive for gold.

Upside risks to our outlook are growing

Our forecast of \$4,150/oz for the fourth quarter (average price) assumes that persistent inflation keeps US monetary policy restrictive and prevents a sustained fall in yields. However, renewed ETF buying, a weaker dollar and mounting fiscal concerns are creating increasingly clear upside risks to our outlook.

Gold's correction appears to have found a floor. Renewed ETF buying and its resilience despite elevated yields suggest the recovery is on firmer footing, but further gains will depend on whether investment demand continues to build and how the Fed responds to persistent inflation.

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Article | 21 August 2026

CZECH REPUBLIC HUNGARY

CEE & CCA week ahead: Hungary rate decision, Polish retail sales and Czech confidence

Next week, we're looking for an expected rate cut from the National Bank of Hungary at Tuesday's meeting. Key data releases from Poland and the Czech Republic are also in focus, including retail sales, labour market figures, confidence indicators and details of second-quarter GDP prints



We're expecting Tuesday to mark the last step in the NBH's mini rate-cutting cycle, but we don't think the story will end there

Poland: Retail sales to feel the impact of higher fuel prices

Monday brings July retail sales data. The standard VAT rate on petrol and diesel (23%) was reinstated at the beginning of July following a temporary reduction to 8%. Together with another increase in crude oil prices, this pushed up retail fuel prices at the pumps. Given the relatively inelastic demand for fuel, particularly during the summer holiday season, it likely weighed on demand for other goods, as a larger share of household budgets was allocated to transport. Despite the fuel price shock, the impact on consumer demand appears to have remained limited so far, partly owing to fiscal measures that moderated the extent of price

increases at filling stations in the previous months.

Tuesday sees the release of the registered unemployment rate, which we expect to have remained unchanged from June. However, the Ministry of Family, Labour and Social Policy reported a slight increase in the number of unemployed people last month, which could result in a marginal rise in the registered unemployment rate.

Hungary: Rate cut expected as focus shifts to further easing

The final interest rate decision of the summer on Tuesday is approaching, marking the last step in the previously announced mini-rate-cut cycle. However, we are almost certain that this isn't the end of the story, and that the mini-cycle will evolve into a midi-cycle. The July inflation data clearly sets the stage for this.

At the same time, we doubt the August interest rate decision will concern anything other than the current situation. The central bank has made it quite clear on countless occasions that the decision on whether to continue the easing cycle will be made in light of the September Inflation Report. The 1.2% inflation rate in July falls outside the uncertainty range of the National Bank of Hungary's June forecast, meaning the overall inflation picture has clearly improved.

However, this is unlikely to prompt NBH Governor Mihály Varga and his colleagues to draw hasty conclusions or make premature announcements. In today's rapidly changing world, where geopolitical and global trade developments rewrite economic scenarios every 24 hours, the NBH is unlikely to commit to anything at this point. Forward guidance may, however, include a conditional statement regarding the inflation outlook that could signal continued interest rate cuts. According to our forecast, the Hungarian base rate could reach 4.75% by the end of 2026.

Czech Republic: Confidence indicators and GDP details in focus

Monday brings August consumer confidence data. We expect that it edged marginally lower in August yet remained well above its long-term average. That said, households are beginning to express concern about the impact of geopolitical unrest on the future performance of the Czech economy and potentially on their own financial position. Business confidence is set to have marginally picked up in the same month, while hovering only slightly above its long-term average values.

The driving force here is the relatively strong influx of new orders, while rising input costs remain a drag. The Statistical Office is about to confirm the 2Q26 real GDP figures, while we wonder about the resilience of consumption and fixed investment expenditure within the breakdown of a relatively soft GDP reading.

Key events in CEE & CCA next week

Country	Time (BST)	Data/event	ING	Prev.
Monday 24 August				
Poland	0830	Jul Retail Sales (YoY%)	3.3	6.2
	1300	Jul M3 Money Supply (YoY%)	11.6	11.8
Czech Rep	0800	Aug Consumer Confidence	105.2	105.6
	0800	Aug Business Confidence	100.4	100.2
	0800	Aug Composite Confidence Index	101.2	101.1
Tuesday 25 August				
Poland	0830	Jul Unemployment Rate (%)	5.8	5.8
Hungary	1300	Rate Decision (%)	5.5	5.75
Wednesday 26 August				
Russia	1700	Jul Industrial Output (YoY%)	1.6	0.6
Thursday 27 August				
Turkey	1230	Gross FX Reserves (USD bn)	75.6	71
Hungary	0730	Jun Average Gross Wages (YoY%)	8.4	8.7
Croatia	1000	Q2 GDP (YoY%)	2.4	2.2
Friday 28 August				
Turkey	0800	Jul Trade Balance (USD bn)	-7.4	-10.4
Czech Rep	0800	Q2 Final GDP (QoQ%/YoY%)	0.4/2.0	0.4/2.0
Hungary	0730	Jul Trade Balance Final (EUR mn)	1305	1305
	0730	Jul Unemployment Rate (%)	4.4	4.5

Source: Refinitiv, ING

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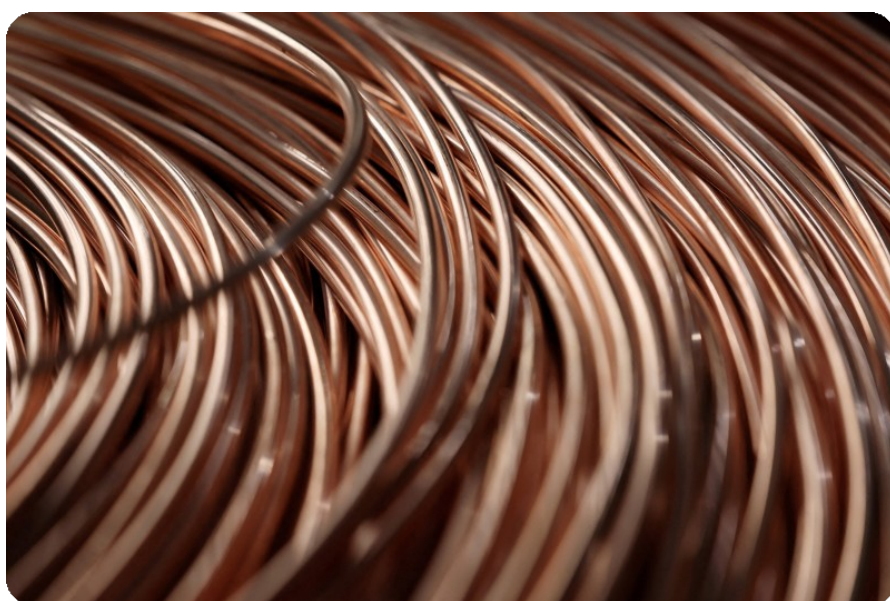
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Article | 7 August 2026

COMMODITIES, FOOD & AGRI

Could copper lose its tariff premium?

Copper has rallied sharply on expectations of US import tariffs, as traders rush metal into the US and physical markets tighten. With prices back near record highs, any policy disappointment could put that tariff premium to the test



Monthly US copper imports surged to a 12-year high of more than 200,000 tonnes in July ahead of potential tariffs

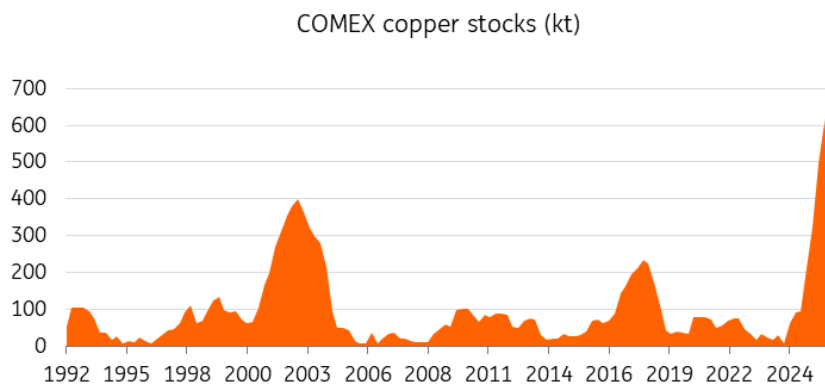
Copper is trading above \$14,000/t, close to its record high. At the same time, LME inventories have fallen further, and the cash-to-three-month spread has moved deeper into backwardation, highlighting increasingly tight physical market conditions.

In our June note, [What's next for US copper import tariffs?](#), we examined the possible policy outcomes. Since then, traders have continued to position for potential tariffs, with the impact becoming increasingly visible in trade flows, inventories and physical market indicators.

Tariff expectations remain a key market driver

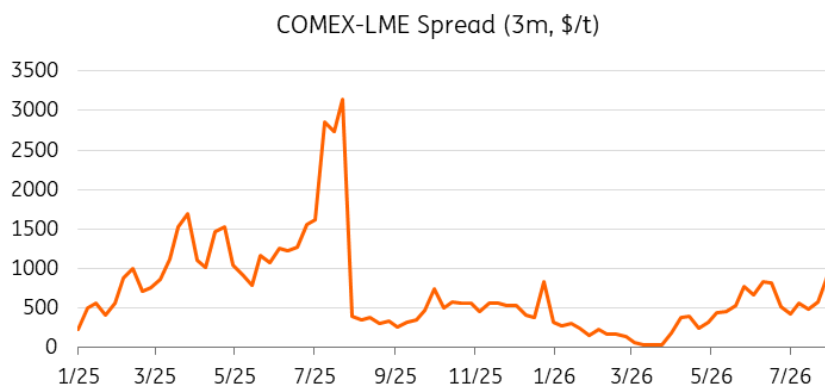
Copper shipments into the US have accelerated ahead of a potential tariff decision, pushing COMEX inventories to a record high. US copper imports exceeded 200,000 tonnes in July alone – the highest monthly level in at least 12 years.

COMEX inventories reach record highs



Source: COMEX, ING Research

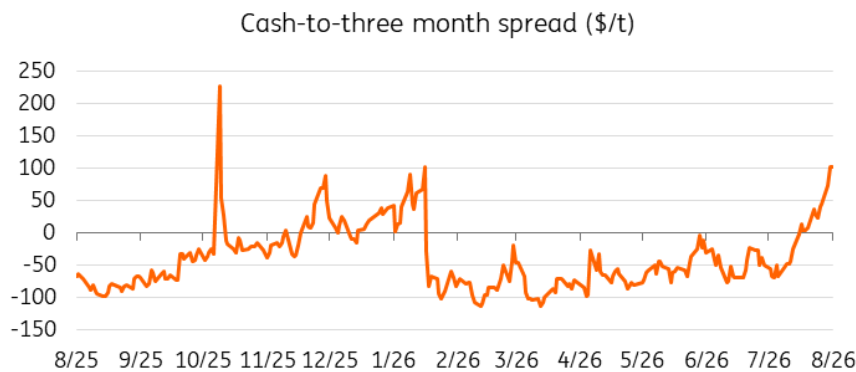
Wide COMEX-LME spread continues to attract copper into the US



Source: COMEX, LME, ING Research

At the same time, the London copper market is showing increasing signs of tightness. LME inventories have fallen to a five-month low, while the cash-to-three-month spread has widened to around \$120/t backwardation – up from about \$40 a week ago and the widest since October, pointing to a squeeze on short-term supplies.

Nearby copper market tightens



Source: LME, ING Research

LME inventories continue to decline



Source: LME, ING Research

Can tariff expectations continue to drive prices?

The recent rally is not solely tariff-driven, however.

Mine supply growth remains constrained, while low treatment charges continue to point to tight concentrate availability. Demand linked to electrification, power grid investment and AI infrastructure also remains supportive. We continue to expect the global refined copper market to record a deficit of around 35k tonnes in 2026.

Much of the recent rally reflects expectations that tariffs will be implemented broadly as expected. But if the final measures are delayed, narrower than expected or exempt refined copper, part of the recent rally could unwind. Stockpiling into the US would slow, inventory flows would begin to normalise, and some of the current tightness outside the US would ease. Any correction could be amplified if investors unwind positions built on tariff expectations.

The tariff decision is only part of the story

The prospect of US tariffs has already reshaped the copper market. Inventory flows have shifted, physical conditions have tightened, and prices have moved back towards record highs.

Much of that repricing has already happened. Once the tariff decision is announced, the market's focus is likely to shift back to underlying fundamentals.

That would not necessarily change the broader outlook for copper. Any correction would be more likely to reflect a reassessment of tariff expectations than a deterioration in the underlying fundamentals.

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